

MAINLAND SOUTHEAST ASIA

STRETCHING FROM THE FOOTHILLS of the Himalayas in the north almost to the Equator in the south, the seven countries of mainland Southeast Asia are largely mountainous. About half the region is covered with forest. Most people live in the river valleys that cut through the fertile countryside. Myanmar is isolated, poor, and underdeveloped. In comparison, Thailand, Malaysia, and, above all, the island of Singapore are rich countries with modern industrial economies. Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos have had to recover from years of war. The region has a monsoon climate, with a dry season from November to March and a wet season from May to October.



THE COMING OF THE RAIN
As the wet season starts in May, the people of Laos and northeast Thailand celebrate *bun bang fai*, the skyrocket festival. They build huge rockets up to 13 ft (4 m) long from steel or plastic pipes and pack them with up to 1,100 lb (500 kg) of gunpowder. The rockets are launched into the sky to prompt the rain god, Vassakarn, to send the annual rains.



THE MEKONG DELTA
The delta of the Mekong River in Vietnam is one of the world's great rice-growing areas, producing much of the surplus that has made Vietnam the world's second largest rice exporter. Farmers in the delta also grow fruit and catch the many breeds of fish that thrive in the muddy river waters.

In the uplands, the river picks up silt, which it carries down to the valleys.

During the monsoon season, the river bursts its banks and floods the surrounding fields.

Silt from the uplands helps fertilize the paddy fields.

RIVER VALLEYS

From ancient times, people have settled in the valleys of the great rivers, such as the Irrawaddy, Mekong, and Salween, because the land there is suitable for growing rice. All the major cities in the region are situated on a river. In the valleys, farmers cultivate every corner of the land, often constructing terraces on the hillsides to grow rice and other crops. They use the river waters to irrigate (water) their crops.



This Akha village on the border of Thailand and Myanmar is surrounded by land that is cleared for slash-and-burn farming.

THE UPLANDS

In contrast to the crowded river valleys, the uplands are sparsely populated and largely covered by forest. Here the hill peoples live in villages, farming small plots of land and gathering fruit and other food from the forest. This traditional way of life is now threatened by the region's growing population and by logging companies, which are cutting down the forest.

Rice is grown near the river, where the paddy fields can be easily watered.



1 and 2: in January an area of forest is cut down and left to dry. During the dry season in April, the area is burned.

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Stages 3 and 4 are repeated for 2–4 years, until the soil becomes less fertile.



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3 and 4: crops are planted during the monsoon rains in May and harvested in October.

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5 and 6: the area is left fallow for 15–25 years and the forest grows back.

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SLASH-AND-BURN FARMING

In the uplands, where there is a lot of land but few people to work it, farmers use a technique called slash-and-burn. An area of forest is cleared and cultivated for a few years, then the farmer moves on to another patch, leaving the original land to recover. In this way, the land is never exhausted, and the forest is not destroyed to create permanent fields.